The earliest compilation to historicize Ashoka via his epigraphs was Alexander Cunningham's *Inscriptions of Asoka*.[38] Cunningham, founding father and first Director General of the Archaeological Survey of India, assembled the available epigraphs into the first volume of the *Corpus Inscriptionum Indicarum*. This epigraphic series aimed to make accessible all the inscriptions of ancient India. Cunningham did a great service to historical knowledge in seeing that a whole volume ought to be devoted to the Ashokan inscriptions (and a few others) that had, till then, been discovered. What added strength to Cunningham's compilation was that the archaeological dimensions of Ashokan sites—which, in many instances, he and his assistants had themselves explored—brought alive the landscapes over which Ashoka had inscribed his words. What may seem surprising from our perspective today—when we know that many of the edicts were inscribed on large rocks in Karnataka and Andhra—is that none of the emperor's southern epigraphs featured in that volume: those would be discovered a little later.[39]

Not all the nineteenth-century discoverers and decipherers, it is necessary to remember, were Europeans. One figure who was discovering Ashokan edicts in Maharashtra and Rajasthan around the same time that Cunningham and his assistants were scouring the countryside was the Indian archaeologist Bhagwanlal Indraji. His work is much less recognized than Cunningham's because the bulk of his early writings was in Gujarati.[40] In a letter of 1872 he reported his discovery of an Ashokan edict at Bairat: 'On the southern side of Virat is a hillock with ancient Buddhist ruins. Near the ruins once stood an engraved stone inscription of Ashoka, which at present lies in the Asiatic Society Museum in Calcutta. While I was on the northern side of Virat, I discovered a new inscription at the foothill. The inscription is broken, yet much of its portion is in a readable condition.'[41] Copies were made of this epigraph, but since his letter containing the details of his discovery was published in Gujarati in *Saurashtra Darpan*, he got no